

Nicaragua

 Occasionally called the land of lakes and volcanoes, Nicaragua lies at the heart of Central America. Volcanoes and earthquakes frequently shake the country, and Hurricane Mitch caused great damage in 1998. In 1978, Nicaragua experienced a civil war between the left-wing Sandinista government and right-wing "contras", backed by the USA. The war ended in 1990.

Delivery of sugar-cane



Farming

Agriculture employs about one-quarter of the work-force, growing cotton, coffee, sugar, bananas, and meat for export. The country has also developed related industries, such as sugar refineries and canning factories that process agricultural produce.



People

Mestizos make up 70 per cent of Nicaraguans. The rest are whites or blacks, descended from Africans who were taken to Nicaragua as plantation workers in the 18th century. Three-quarters of the population is below the age of 30. Families are tight-knit, and up to three generations may live together.



Food

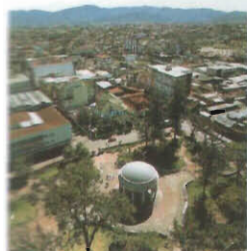
Nicaraguans enjoy maize roasted on the cob. Meat and bean dishes are spiced with pepper and garlic and scooped up in thin pancakes called tortillas, which are made from maize flour. Food is often topped with hot chilli sauce.

NICARAGUA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Managua
AREA	130,000 sq km (50,193 sq miles)
POPULATION	5,100,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Spanish, English, Creole, Miskito
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Córdoba oro

Costa Rica

 Unlike its neighbours, Costa Rica is a stable and peaceful country with a democratically elected government. The army was abolished in 1949. Costa Ricans enjoy excellent schools and hospitals. Most people are *mestizos* of Spanish origin. In the Puerto Limón area on the east coast, one-third are English-speaking blacks, descended from plantation



San José

Founded in 1737, San José became Costa Rica's capital in 1823. With many parks and a mix of traditional and modern Spanish architecture, San José is a commercial centre and has food-processing factories. It has rail links with Pacific and Caribbean ports and lies on the Pan-American Highway.



Tourism

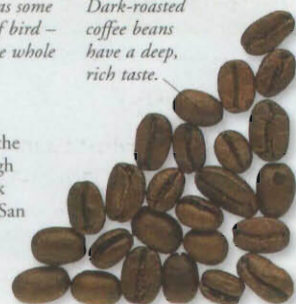
More than 20 per cent of Costa Rica has been set aside to create a network of national parks, including volcanic peaks and undisturbed tropical forest rich in plant and animal species. Many ecotourists are attracted by the country's resident wildlife, such as jaguars, giant sea turtles, crocodiles, and armadillos.

Coffee

Costa Rican coffee is some of the world's finest, and fetches a high price. It grows in the rich black volcanic soils near the capital, San José. Costa Rica was the first Central American country to grow the beans. Bananas are the other leading cash crop.

Costa Rica has some 750 species of bird – more than the whole of the USA.

Dark-roasted coffee beans have a deep, rich taste.

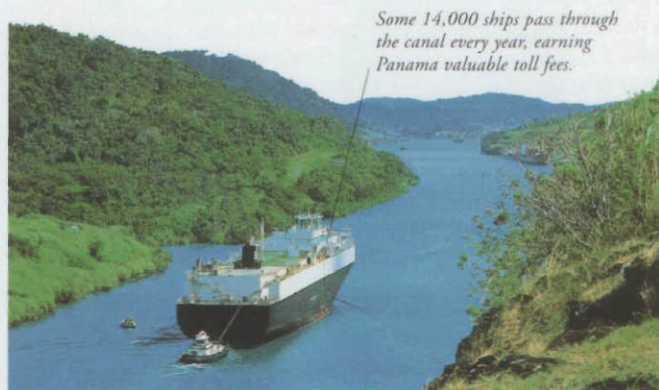


COSTA RICA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	San José
AREA	51,100 sq km (19,730 sq miles)
POPULATION	4,000,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Spanish, English, Creole, Bribri, Cabecar
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Colón

Panama

 Occupying the southernmost and narrowest part of Central America, Panama is cut in two by the Panama Canal, which links the Atlantic and Pacific Oceans. A country of swamps, mountains, and grassy plains, Panama has some of Central America's wildest rainforest.



Some 14,000 ships pass through the canal every year, earning Panama valuable toll fees.

Financial centres

At opposite ends of the Panama Canal, Colón and Panama City are important business centres, providing banking, financial, and insurance services. A free trade zone in Colón enables goods to be imported and exported free of duty.

Panama Canal

Linking the Caribbean Sea with the Pacific Ocean, the Panama Canal was built by the USA, and opened in 1914. It is more than 65 km (40 miles) long, and passes through three sets of locks. The length, which is the distance between deep-water points of entry, is 82 km (51 miles).

PANAMA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Panama City
AREA	77,080 sq km (29,761 sq miles)
POPULATION	2,900,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Spanish, English, Creole, Indian languages
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Balboa



Shrimps

Panama has a busy and important fishing fleet. The leading catch is shrimps, which form 11 per cent of the country's exports. Anchovetas, small fishes used for fish meal, make up three per cent of exports. Other catches include herrings and lobsters.

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